

GEORG WILHELM
FRIEDRICH HEGEL
The Phenomenology of Spirit

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A. *True Spirit, Ethical Life*

241 443. In its simple truth, spirit is consciousness, and it forces its moments away from each other. *Action* divides spirit into substance and the consciousness of substance, and it divides substance just as much as it does consciousness. As universal *essence* and *purpose*, substance confronts itself as an isolated actuality. The infinite mediating middle is self-consciousness, which is *in itself* the unity of itself and substance, which now becomes *for itself*, unifies the universal essence and its isolated actuality, raises the latter to the former, and acts ethically – and it brings the former down to the latter and accomplishes the purpose, which is substance as it has been rendered into thought.⁸ It engenders the unity of its own self and substance as *its work*⁹ and thereby as *actuality*.

444. In the coming apart of consciousness, the simple substance has in part sustained an opposition to self-consciousness, and in part, thereby just as much presents in itself the nature of consciousness, [which is] to differentiate itself as a world divided into social estates.¹⁰ The substance thus fissures into a differentiated ethical essence, into a human and a divine law. Likewise, according to its essence, self-consciousness, in confronting substance, assigns itself to one of these powers, and, as knowing, it divides itself into both an ignorance of what it is doing and a knowing of what it is doing, and it is thus a deceived knowing. In its deed, it thus experiences the contradiction of *those powers* into which substance estranged itself, and it experiences their mutual destruction and the contradiction in its knowing of the ethical life of its actions – the contradiction of what ethical life is in and for itself – and it meets *its own* downfall. However, through this movement, ethical substance has in fact become *actual self-consciousness*, or *this* self has come to be *in-and-for-itself*-existing, but it was just therein that ethical life perished.

a. *The Ethical World, the Human and Divine Law, Man and Woman*

445. The simple substance of spirit divides itself up as consciousness, or, as consciousness of abstract sensuous being passes over into perception, so does the immediate certainty of real ethical being also pass over, and just as simple being becomes for sense-perception a thing of many properties, so for ethical perception a case of acting becomes an actuality of many ethical relations. However, to the former, the useless plurality of properties is condensed into the essential opposition between singularity and universality,

⁸ nur gedachte.⁹ *Werk*. Here the meaning is “work,” and not “labor” (*Arbeit*).¹⁰ Massen.

and for the latter, which is purified, substantial consciousness, the plurality of ethical moments condenses itself instead into the twofoldness of a law of singular individuality and a law of universality. However, each of these social estates of substance remains the whole spirit. If the things in sense-perception have no substance other than the two determinations of singularity and universality, here they only express the superficial opposition of both aspects to each other. 242

446. In the essence we are here considering, the meaning of singular individuality is that of *self-consciousness* in general, not that of a singular, contingent consciousness. In this determination, the ethical substance is thus the *actual* substance, absolute spirit *realized* in the plurality of determinately existing *consciousnesses*. The spirit is the *polity*,¹¹ which, when we entered into the practical shaping of reason itself, was *for us* the absolute essence and which here emerges in its truth *for itself* as a conscious ethical essence and as the *essence for the consciousness* which we now have as our object. It is spirit which is *for itself*, while it sustains itself within the *counter-glow*¹² of the *individuals* – and which is *in itself*, or is substance while it sustains the individuals within itself. As the actual *substance*, it is *a people*, and as *actual consciousness*, it is the *citizens* of the nation.¹³ This consciousness has its *essence* in simple spirit, and its certainty of itself in the *actuality* of this spirit, in the whole people, and it immediately therein has its *truth*. But it does not have its truth in something which is not actual; it has it in a spirit which *exists* and *is validly in force*.¹⁴

447. This spirit can be called the human law because it is essentially in the form of *actuality conscious of itself*. In the form of universality, it is the *familiarly known* law and *extant* mores which are both *present*. In the form of singularity, it is the actual certainty of itself in the *individual* as such, and in the certainty of itself as *simple individuality*, it is the government. Its truth is the *validity in force* which is publicly open to the light of day. It is an *existence* which, for immediate certainty, takes on the form of existence¹⁵ set free-standing.

¹¹ *Gemeinwesen*.

¹² *Gegenschein*. This word occurs in English dictionaries as a loan word from German, and it literally means “counter-glow” (as I have rendered it here instead of leaving it as “*Gegenschein*”). It is sometimes rendered as “opposition-effect.” It is a diffuse, faint light which is sometimes visible at a spot in the night sky at the point at which the sun is focused on the opposite side of the earth; it is believed to be sunlight which is reflected by dust particles in the atmosphere.

¹³ The word for “people” and “nation” here is the same German word, *Volk*. In other writings, however, Hegel distinguishes between a “*Nation*” and a “*Volk*.”

¹⁴ *der existiert und gilt*.

¹⁵ The first “existence” in the sentence is “*Existenz*,” whereas the second “existence” in the sentence is “*Dasein*.”

448. However, another power confronts this ethical power and public: the *divine law*, for the ethical *power of the state* has its opposite in the *simple* and *immediate essence* of ethical life as the *movement* of self-conscious acting. As actual *universality*, the power of the state is a force confronting the individual being-for-itself, and as actuality itself, it still has in the *inner* essence something other than itself.

449. We have already been reminded that each of the opposed ways in which the ethical substance exists wholly contains that substance and all the moments of its contents. However much the polity is therefore the substance as awareness of its actual doings, still the other aspect has the form of immediate, or existing, substance. In that way, the existing substance is, on the one hand, the inner concept, or the universal possibility of ethical life in general, but, on the other hand, it just as much has in it the moment of self-consciousness. This moment expressing ethical life in this element of *immediacy*, or in the element of *being*, or an *immediate* consciousness of
 243 itself as essence as well as being this self in an other, which is to say, as a *natural ethical* polity – this moment is the *family*. As the *unaware* concept of its consciously aware actuality, as the *elemental unit*¹⁶ of the actuality of the people, as, to the people, *immediate* ethical being – as the ethical life educating, acculturating, and sustaining itself through the *work* for the universal, as the Penates [household divinities], the family stands over and against the universal spirit.

450. However, whether or not the *ethical being* of the family is determined as *immediate* being, it is not in its *ethical* essence *to the extent that* it is the *natural* relationship of its members, or to the extent that their relation is the *immediate relation of singular actual members*, for the ethical is in itself *universal*, and this natural relationship is essentially just one spirit and only as spiritual essence is it ethical. How this distinctive ethical life is constituted remains to be seen. – In the first place, because the ethical is the universal in itself, the ethical relation among the members of the family is neither a relation of sentiment, nor is it the relationship of love. Now it seems that the ethical must have been placed into the relationship which the *individual* members of the family bear to the *whole* family as substance, such that the singular individual's acts and the individual's actuality have only that substance for their purpose and their content. However, the conscious purpose which is the *doing* of this whole, insofar as this purpose has to do with the whole, is itself the singular individual. The acquisition and sustaining of power and wealth have in part to do only with needs,

¹⁶ das *Element*.

and they involve desire; in their higher determination, they in part become something that is only mediated. This [higher] determination does not fall within the bounds of the family itself but concerns what is truly universal, the polity. This determination is instead negative vis-à-vis the family; it consists in taking the singular individual out of the family, in subjugating his naturalness and individuality, and thus in leading him towards *virtue*, towards a life lived in and for the universal. The *positive* purpose distinctive of the family is the individual as such a singular individual. For this relationship to be ethical, neither he who acts nor he to whom the action is related can come on the scene *contingently*, as happens in some form of assistance or service to be rendered. The content of the ethical action must be substantial, or, whole and universal. Hence, the action can only be related to the *whole* individual, or, to the individual as universal. Again, this must also not be so understood that it would be *represented* as doing him *some service* to further his entire happiness, since such service, as it is an immediate and *actual action*, only does something very singular to him – nor must it be represented that ethical action is actually education, in a *series* of endeavors having him as a whole as its object and which bring him out as its accomplished work. Apart from the purpose which is negative vis-à-vis the family, the *actual action* in such an education has only a restricted content – and finally, it should even less be represented that such service is a type of “help in time of need” through which the whole individual is in truth saved, for such service is itself an entirely contingent deed, the occasion for which is an everyday actuality that can just as well be as not be. Therefore the action, which embraces the entire existence of blood relations, has as its object and content the singular individual – not the citizen, for he does not belong to the family, nor does it have the singular individual who is to become a citizen and is supposed to *cease* counting as *this singular individual* – but rather, it has as the object the individual who as *this* singular individual belongs to the family, and who as a *universal* being,¹⁷ is exempted from his sensuous, i.e., singular actuality. The action no longer concerns the *living* but rather the *dead*; it concerns he who, out of the long progression of his dispersed existence, is condensed into *one* completed shape and who has been elevated out of the unrest of contingent life into the motionlessness of simple universality. – Because he is only *actual* and *substantial* as a citizen, the singular individual, taken not as a citizen but as belonging to the family, is only the *unreal*¹⁸ shadow without any core.

244

¹⁷ Wesen.¹⁸ unwirkliche.

451. This universality to which the singular individual as *such a singular individual* has arrived is *pure being, death*; it is what has *naturally and immediately come about*¹⁹ and is not something a *consciousness* does. The duty of the family member is thus to augment this aspect so that his final *being*, this *universal* being, will also not belong solely to nature and remain something non-rational. It is to make it so that it too may be *something done*, and that the right of consciousness would be asserted within that being. Or, the sense of the action is instead that because the motionlessness and universality of a self-aware essence does not in truth belong to nature, the semblance that this is the kind of act which can be ascribed to nature falls by the wayside, and the truth is established. – What nature did in him is the aspect by which his coming to be the universal itself appears as the movement of an *existent*. To be sure, the movement itself falls within the ethical polity, and it has this polity as its purpose. Death is the consummation and the highest work that the individual as such undertakes for the polity. However, insofar as he is essentially *singularly individual*, it is contingent as to whether his death was both immediately connected with and was the result of his work for the universal. This is so in part because if it was, then it would be the *natural* negativity and movement of the individual as an *existent*, within which consciousness does not return into itself and become self-consciousness. Or, while the movement of the *existent* consists in its having been sublated and in its having arrived at *being-for-itself*, death is the aspect of estrangement in which the being-for-itself at which it arrived is something other than the existent which entered into the movement. – Because ethical life is spirit in its *immediate* truth, the aspects into which its consciousness was dispersed also fall into this form of *immediacy*, and singular individuality crosses over into this *abstract* negativity, which, without consolation or reconciliation *in itself*, must receive it *essentially* through an *actual* and *external action*. – The blood-relationship therefore supplements the abstract natural movement by adding to it the movement of consciousness, by interrupting nature's work, and by wresting the blood-relation away from destruction; or, better, because destruction, the individual's becoming pure being, is necessary, the blood-relationship takes upon itself the deed of destruction. – It thereby comes to pass that the *dead*, universal *being*, is elevated into a being returned into itself, a *being-for-itself*, or the powerless pure *singular* singularity is elevated to *universal individuality*. He who is dead, by having his *being* set free from his *doing*, or his negative oneness, is empty singular individuality, only a passive *being for*

245

¹⁹ das unmittelbare natürliche Gewordensein.

others, and is left to the mercy of every lower individuality devoid of reason and to the forces of abstract matter, both of which are now more powerful than he, or the former lower creatures on account of the life that they have and the latter forces of matter on account of their negative nature. The family keeps the dead away from those dishonoring acts of unconscious desire and abstract creatures,²⁰ and in place of them, it puts their own acts; it wedds their kin to the womb of the earth, to the elemental, imperishable individuality. The family thereby makes the dead into a member of a polity which instead overwhelms and keeps in check the powers of the particular elements of matter and the lower living creatures which come to be free from him and which sought to destroy him.

452. This last duty thus constitutes the consummate *divine* law, or it constitutes the positive *ethical* action vis-à-vis the singular individual. All other relationships in regard to him, those which do not remain stalled in love [for him] but rather which are ethical, belong to human law, and their negative meaning is that of the elevation of the singular individual above his confinement within the natural polity to which he belongs as an *actual* individual. Now, however much human law²¹ has for its content and power the actual ethical substance conscious of itself, the whole people; and divine right and law have their content and power in the singular individual who is in the other-worldly realm beyond actuality, still the singular individual is not powerless. His power is that of the *abstract* pure *universal*, the *elemental* individual, which constitutes the individuality which tears itself loose from the elements and the self-conscious actuality of the people, withdraws back into the pure abstraction as into its essence as their ground. – How this power will exhibit itself in the people themselves is something which is still to be further developed.

453. Now, there are *differences* and *levels* in the one law as well as in the other. For while both essences have the moment of consciousness in themselves, the difference unfolds itself within themselves, which constitutes their movement and distinctive life. The examination of these differences shows the way in which they *engage themselves*²² and the *self-consciousness* of the two *universal essences* of the ethical world, as well as showing their *connection* and their *transition* into each other.

454. The *polity*, the higher, valid law open to the light of day, has its actual liveliness in the *government* within which it is individual. The government is actual spirit *reflected into itself*, the simple *self* of the whole ethical substance. This simple force allows the essence to diffuse itself into its

²⁰ Wesen.²¹ Recht.²² Betätigung.

members and to give to each part both a stable existence and its own being-for-itself. It is there that spirit has its *reality*, or its *existence*, and the family is the *elemental unit*²³ of this reality. However, spirit is at the same time the force of the whole, which again assembles these parts into a negative One, gives them the feeling of their non-self-sufficiency, and sustains them in the consciousness that they have their life only in the whole. On the one hand, the polity may thus organize itself into the systems of personal self-sufficiency, property, personal rights, and rights in things; and it may just as well organize the various ways of working for what are initially singular purposes – those of acquisition and consumption – such that it subdivides them into their own assemblies and makes those assemblies self-sufficient. The spirit of the universal gathering is the *simplicity* and the *negative* essence of these self-isolating systems. In order not to let them become rooted and rigidly fixed within this activity of isolating themselves, which would otherwise let the whole come undone and the spirit within it fade away, the government must from time to time shake them to their core by means of war. As a result, it infringes on their established order, violates their right to self-sufficiency, and throws them into disarray. By the labor the government imposes on them, those individuals, who have become more and more absorbed in their own lives and who thereby tend to tear themselves loose from the whole in striving after inviolable *being-for-itself* and personal security, are made to feel the power of their lord and master, death. Through this dissolution of the form of stable existence, spirit wards off its descent from out of ethical life into only natural existence, and it sustains and elevates the self of its consciousness into *freedom* and into its *force*. – The negative essence shows itself to be the polity's underlying *power* and the *force* of its self-preservation. The polity therefore has the truth and substantiation of its power in the essence of the *divine* law and in the *realm of the netherworld*.

455. Likewise, the divine law prevailing in the family has for its part differences within itself, and the relations among those differences constitute the living movement of its actuality. However, among the three relationships of man and wife, parents and children, and siblings as brothers and sisters, it is the *relationship of man and wife* which is initially the immediate self-cognizance²⁴ of one consciousness in another and the cognizance of reciprocal recognition. Because it is *natural* self-cognizance and not ethical self-cognizance, it is only the *representation* and *picture* of spirit, not actual spirit itself. – However, the representation, or the picture, has its actuality

²³ das *Element*.²⁴ Sich-erkennen.

in an other than itself; this relationship therefore does not have its actuality in its own self but in the child – in an other whose coming into being is that relationship and in which the relationship disappears. This progression from one generation to another has its stable existence in the people. – The piety of man and wife towards each other is thus intermixed with both a natural relation and with sentiment, and their relationship does not in its own self have its return into itself, nor does the second relationship, that of the *piety of parents and children* to each other. The piety of parents towards their children is affected by the emotion brought on by their awareness that they have their actuality in an other and that they see their children come to their own being-for-itself without the parents being able to get it back. The child's being for itself remains an alien actuality, an actuality all its own. – But conversely the devotion of children towards their parents is affected by the emotion of their coming-to-be, or having their own in-itself in an other who is vanishing, and in achieving being-for-itself and their own self-consciousness only through separation from their origin – a separation within which the origin recedes. 247

456. Both these relationships come to a standstill in the transitions and the inequality of the aspects that are assigned to them. – However, the unmixed relationship is found between *brother* and *sister*. They are the same blood; however, in them it has reached its state of *rest* and *equilibrium*. Hence, they neither desire each other, nor have they given or received this being-for-itself to each other. Rather, they are free individualities with respect to each other. The feminine, as the sister, hence has the highest *intimation* of ethical essence. This intimation does not rise to a *consciousness* of the actuality of ethical essence because the law of the family is the *inner* essence existing-*in-itself*, which does not lie in the daylight of consciousness. Rather, it remains inner feeling, the divine displaced from actuality. The feminine is bound to these Penates, and it is in those Penates that she partly intuits her universal substance and partly intuits her singular individuality, though at the same time this relation of singular individuality is not the natural relation of pleasure. – As a *daughter*, the woman must now see her parents vanish, and she must be herself both naturally moved by that loss and be at ethical peace, for it is only at the expense of this relationship that she can achieve the *being-for-itself* of which she is capable. She thus cannot intuit her being-for-itself positively in her parents. However, the relations of *mother* and *wife* have singular individuality partly as something natural, something to which pleasure is appropriate, and partly as something negative, which in the relationship can only behold therein its own disappearance, and in part as something contingent which can be

replaced by another individuality. In the household of ethical life, it is not *this* man, and it is not *this* child; rather, it is *a man, children as such* – these female relationships are grounded not on sentiment but on the universal. The difference between her ethical life and the man's ethical life consists in this, that in her destiny²⁵ for singular individuality and in her pleasure, she remains both immediately universal and alien to the individuality of desire, whereas in the man, these two aspects become separated; and while as a citizen, he possesses the *self-conscious* power of *universality*, the life of the social whole, as a result he purchases for himself the right of *desire* while at the same time maintaining his freedom from such desire. While singular individuality is thus mingled into the woman's relationship, her ethical life is not pure. However, insofar as she is ethical, singular individuality is a matter of *indifference*, and the wife dispenses with the moment of cognizing herself as *this* self in an other. – But to the sister, the brother is the motionless essence itself, equal to her, and her recognition²⁶ in him is pure and unmixed with any natural relation. The indifference of singular individuality and its ethical contingency is thus not present in this relationship. Rather, the moment of the *singular self*, as recognizing and being recognized, may here assert its right because it is bound up with the equilibrium of blood relations and with relations utterly devoid of desire. The loss of a brother is thus irreplaceable to the sister, and her duty towards him is the highest.

457. This relationship is at the same time the limit at which the self-enclosed family dissolves and moves outside of itself. The brother is the aspect according to which the family's spirit becomes that of individuality that turns itself against the other and makes its transition into the consciousness of universality. The brother leaves this *immediate, elemental*, and for that reason genuinely *negative* ethical life of the family in order to acquire and to bring out the actual ethical life which is conscious of itself.

458. He makes a transition from the divine law, in whose sphere he had lived, to the human law. However, either the sister becomes, or the wife remains, the overseer of the household and the guardian of the divine law. In this way, both the sexes overcome their natural essence, and they emerge in their ethical significance as diversities who divide between them the two differences that ethical substance gives itself. These two *universal* essences of the ethical world have their determinate *individuality* in *naturally* differentiated self-consciousnesses, because the ethical spirit is the *immediate* unity of substance with self-consciousness, an *immediacy* which thus,

²⁵ Bestimmung. ²⁶ Anerkennung.

according to the aspect of reality and difference, at the same time appears as the existence of a natural difference. – It is the aspect which appeared in the shape of the individuality which is real, to itself, or in the concept of spiritual essence, as *original determinate nature*. This moment loses the indeterminateness which it still had there and loses the contingent diversity of aptitudes and capacities. It is now the determinate opposition of the two sexes, whose naturalness at the same time sustains the meaning of their ethical destiny.

459. The difference between the sexes and their ethical content nonetheless remains within the unity of the substance, and the difference's movement is just the abiding coming to be of that substance. The spirit of the family sends the man out into the polity, and he finds his self-conscious essence in that polity. Just as the family has its universal substance and its stable existence in the polity, the polity conversely has the formal element of its own actuality in the family and its force and proof in the divine laws. Neither of the two alone is in and for itself. In its vital movement, human law originates from the divine law, the law in force on earth originates from the law of the netherworld, the conscious law originates from the unconscious law, mediation originates from immediacy, and all just as much return to that from whence they came. In contrast, the netherworldly power has its *actuality* on the earth, and through consciousness, it becomes existence and activity.

249

460. The universal ethical essences are thus the substance as universal consciousness and as singular consciousness. They have the people and the family for their universal actuality, and they have man and wife for their natural self and their activating individuality. In this content of the ethical world, we see that the purposes which the previous substanceless shapes of consciousness had set for themselves are now achieved. What reason only grasped as an object has become self-consciousness, and what self-consciousness only possessed within itself is here present as true actuality. – What observation knew as *an item as it found it*, in which the self would have had no share, is here a set of given mores, an actuality which is at the same time the deed and work of those who are finding themselves in it. – The singular individual seeking the pleasure of *relishing his singular individuality* finds it in the family, and the necessity within which that pleasure slips away is his own self-consciousness as a citizen of his nation – or, it is the knowing of the *law of the heart* as the law of all hearts, the consciousness of the *self* as the recognized universal order of society – it is *virtue*, which enjoys the fruits of its own sacrifice and which brings about what it is concerned with, namely, to lift the essence out of the actual present,

and its own relish to be in this universal life. – Finally, consciousness of the *crux of the matter* is satisfied within the real substance, which contains and sustains in a positive manner the abstract moments of that empty category. The substance has a genuine content in the ethical powers, a content that takes the place of the insubstantial commands which healthy rationality wanted to give and to know – just as it thereby obtains a material standard which in its own self is self-determined,²⁷ not for the testing of laws but for testing what is done.

461. The whole is a peaceful equilibrium of all the parts, and each part is a local spirit that does not seek its satisfaction beyond itself. Rather, each local spirit has its satisfaction within itself because it is itself in this equilibrium with the whole. – To be sure, this equilibrium can only be a living equilibrium because of an inequality that arises within it, an inequality which is then brought back to equality by *justice*. However, justice is neither an alien essence which is situated somewhere off in the other-worldly beyond, nor is it the actuality of mutual maliciousness, treasonous behavior, ingratitude, etc., an actuality unworthy of the name of justice and which would execute judgment in an unthinking and arbitrary way without even thinking about the context, or in unconscious acts of omission and commission.

250 Rather, as the justice of *human* law, it is that which brings back into the universal the being-for-itself, or the self-sufficiency, of the estates and singular individuals who are moving out of and away from that equilibrium. As such, justice is the government of the people, which is, to itself, the current individuality of the universal essence and the self-conscious will of all. – However, in bringing the universal back into equilibrium, a universal which is becoming ever more dominant over singular individuals, justice is likewise the simple spirit of he who has suffered wrong. – It has not been subverted into he who has suffered wrong and an other-worldly essence. He himself is the power of the netherworld, and it is *his* Erinyes [the Furies] which take vengeance, since his individuality, his blood, still lives on in the household, and his substance has an enduring actuality. In the realm of ethical life, the wrong that can be inflicted upon the singular individual would only be this, that something purely and simply *happens* to him. Nature is the power that commits this wrong to consciousness, that makes it into a pure thing, and the wrong is the universality not of the *polity* but rather that of the *abstract* universality of *being*. In undoing the wrong it has suffered, singular individuality does not turn against the polity because it has not suffered at the polity's hands; rather, he or she turns against nature. As

²⁷ an ihm selbstbestimmten Maßstab der Prüfung.

we saw, the consciousness of the blood [relations] of the individual undoes this wrong so that what was *a mere event* becomes, on the contrary, a *work*, and, as a result, *being*, a *finality*, is supposed to be something also *willed* and hence also something gratifying.

462. The ethical realm is in this way an undefiled world in its *stable existence*, a world unpolluted by any division. Likewise, its movement consists in one of its powers peacefully coming to be the other so that each preserves and brings forth the other. To be sure, we see it dividing itself into two essences and their actuality, but their opposition is instead the proof of one through the other, and their mediating middle and element is the immediate permeation of each by the other in which they immediately come into contact with each other as actual powers. One of the extremes, universal spirit conscious of itself, is integrated²⁸ with its other extreme, its force and its element, or it is integrated with *unconscious* spirit through the *individuality* of the *man*. In contrast, the *divine* law has its individualization, or the singular individual's *unconscious* spirit has its existence in the woman through which, as the mediating middle, the unconscious spirit rises out of its non-actuality into actuality and steps out of the realm of unknowing and the unknown into the conscious realm. The union of man with woman constitutes the active mediating middle of the whole, and it constitutes the elemental unit²⁹ which, estranged into the extremes of divine and human law, is just as much their immediate union. It makes the first two syllogisms into the same syllogism and unites the opposed movements into *one* movement from actuality down to non-actuality – a downward movement of the human law, which has organized itself into self-sufficient members, towards danger and trial by death – and an upward movement of the laws of the netherworld towards the actuality of daylight and to conscious existence. Of these movements the former falls to man, the latter to woman.

251

b. Ethical Action, Human and Divine Knowing, Guilt and Fate

463. The way in which the opposition is constituted in this realm is such that self-consciousness has not yet emerged in its right as *singular individuality*. From one aspect, individuality counts in self-consciousness only as the *universal will*, but from another aspect, it counts in it as the *blood* of

²⁸ zusammengeschlossen. Hegel plays with the “*schließen*” in *Zusammenschließen* to highlight the way in which this also indicates how the terms of a syllogism and an inference come together in the conclusion.

²⁹ das *Element*.

the family. *This singular individual* counts *only* as the *non-actual shade*. – As yet, *no deed* has been committed; but the deed is the *actual self*. – It disturbs the peaceful organization and movement of the ethical world. What appears as order and harmony between both of its essences, each of which proves the worth of the other and completes the other, becomes through the deed a transition of *opposites* within which instead each proves itself to be the nullity, not the authentication, of itself and the other – it becomes the negative movement, or the eternal necessity of a dreadful *fate* which in the abyss of its *simplicity* engulfs both the divine and the human law as well as that of the two self-consciousnesses in which these powers have their existence – and for us it makes a transition into the *absolute being-for-itself* of pure singularly individual self-consciousness.

252 464. The ground from which this movement both starts and on which it advances is the realm of ethical life, but this movement's *activity* is self-consciousness. As *ethical* consciousness, it is the *simple, pure direction* towards ethical essentiality, or duty. Within it, there is neither arbitrary choice nor is there struggle or indecision, as it has forsaken both giving the law and testing the law. Rather, to itself, the ethical essentiality is the immediate, the unwavering, what is free of contradiction. There is therefore neither the painful spectacle of a collision between passion and duty, nor the comical spectacle of a collision between duty and duty – a collision, which according to its content is the same as that between passion and duty, for passion is just as capable of being represented as duty. This is because duty, like consciousness withdrawing itself back into itself from out of its immediate essentiality, becomes a formal-universal with which, just as it did before, any content corresponds equally well. However, the collision of duties is comical because it expresses the contradiction in an *absolute* which is *opposed* to itself and thus an absolute which is immediately the nullity of this so-called absolute or duty. – However, ethical consciousness knows what it has to do, and it has decided whether it is to belong to divine or to human law. This immediacy is a *being-in-itself* and hence, as we have seen, its meaning is at the same time that of a natural being. It is nature, not the accident of circumstances or of choice, which assigns one sex to one law and the other to the other law – or, conversely, it is both ethical powers which give themselves their individual existence and their actualization in the two sexes.

465. Now, because on the one hand ethical life consists essentially in this immediate *decisiveness*, and for that reason only *one* law is the essence for consciousness, on the other hand, it is because the ethical powers are actual in the *self* of consciousness that these forces receive the significance

of *excluding* each other and of being *opposed* to each other – they exist *for itself* in self-consciousness just as they only exist *in itself* within the realm of ethical life. Because it has *decided* in favor of *one* of them, ethical consciousness is essentially *character*. It is not the equal essentiality of both which is for ethical consciousness; and for that reason, the opposition appears only as an *unfortunate* collision of duty with an *actuality* utterly devoid of any right. Ethical consciousness is in this opposition as self-consciousness, and as such it sets itself to subordinate by force the actuality opposed to the law to which it belongs, or to deceive this opposed actuality. While it sees right only on its own side and sees only wrong on the other, the consciousness that belongs to divine law beholds on the other side human, contingent *violence*; and that consciousness which belongs to human law beholds on the other side the obstinacy and *disobedience* of inward being-for-itself. For the commands of government have a universal, public sense lying open to the light of day, but the will of the other law is the sense of the netherworld, sealed up in innerness, a sense which in its existence appears as the will of singular individuality and, when it stands in contradiction to the first, is sacrilege.

466. There thereby arises in consciousness the opposition between the *known* and the *not known*, just as in substance, there was an opposition between the *conscious* and the *unconscious*, and the absolute *right* of ethical self-consciousness comes into conflict with the *divine* right of *essence*. For self-consciousness as consciousness, objective actuality as such objective actuality has essentiality, but according to its substance, self-consciousness is the unity of itself and this opposite, and ethical self-consciousness is the consciousness of substance. For that reason, the object as opposed to self-consciousness has entirely lost the significance of having for itself essence.³⁰ Just as the spheres in which the object is only a *thing* have long since disappeared, so too have these spheres within which consciousness fixes itself on something and then makes a singular moment into the essence. Against such one-sidedness, actuality has a force of its own; it is in league with the truth against consciousness and only presents to consciousness what the truth is. However, from the cup of absolute substance, ethical consciousness has drunk the forgetfulness of all the one-sidedness of being-for-itself, its purposes and its distinctive concepts, and for that reason, it has at the same time drowned all of its own essentiality and the self-sufficient meaning of objective actuality in this Stygian water. Hence, while it acts according to the ethical law, its absolute right is that it find in this actualization nothing

253

³⁰ für sich Wesen zu haben.

but the attainment of this law itself, and it finds that the deed shows nothing other than ethical doing. – The ethical, as the absolute *essence* and at the same time the absolute *power*, cannot suffer any inversion of its content. If it were only absolute *essence* without power, it could experience inversion through individuality. However, as ethical consciousness, this individuality has forgone the inverting activity when it forsook one-sided being-for-itself, just as conversely mere power would be inverted by essence if that power were still such a one-sided being-for-itself. On account of this unity, individuality is the pure form of substance which is the content, and the act is the transition from thought to actuality, but only as the movement of an essenceless opposition whose moments have no particular content and no essentiality distinct from each other. Thus the absolute right of ethical consciousness is that the *deed*, the *shape* of its *actuality*, is supposed to be nothing other than what it *knows*.

254 467. However, the ethical essence has split itself into two laws, and, as a non-estranged conduct towards the laws, consciousness is only assigned to *one of them*. Just as this *simple* consciousness insists on the absolute right that the essence shall *have appeared* to it as it is *in itself*, this essence insists on the right of its *reality*, or on the right to be a doubled essence. However, this right of essence does not at the same time stand over and against self-consciousness, as if it were to exist somewhere else, but rather, it is self-consciousness' own essence, and only there does it have its existence and its power; its opposite is *self-consciousness*' own *deed*. Just because it is, to itself, a self and sets itself to action, self-consciousness elevates itself out of *simple immediacy* and itself posits this *estrangement*. Through the deed, it abandons the determinateness of ethical life, of being the simple certainty of immediate truth, and it posits a separation of itself within itself as that between what is active and what is for it the negative actuality confronting it. Through the deed, it thus becomes *guilt*, since the *deed* is its own doing, and its own doing is its ownmost essence. *Guilt* also takes on the meaning of *crime*, for as simple ethical consciousness, it has addressed itself to one of the laws but has rejected the other, and, by its deed it thus violates that other law. – *Guilt* is not the indifferent, ambiguous essence; it is not as if the deed, as it *actually* lies open to the light of day, might or might not be the guilty self's *own doing*, as if something external and accidental could be attached to the doing which did not belong to it and according to which the doing would therefore be innocent. Rather, the doing is itself this estrangement; it is this positing of itself for itself and this positing of an alien external actuality confronting itself. It belongs to the doing itself that such an actuality is, and it only is through the act. Hence, innocence

amounts to non-action, like the being of a stone, not even that of a child. – However, according to the content, ethical *action* has the moment of crime in itself because it does not sublimate the *natural* distribution of the two laws to the two sexes. Rather, within *natural immediacy*, it remains instead as a *non-estranged* directedness to the law, and, as doing, it makes this one-sidedness into guilt, grapples with only one of essence's aspects, and conducts itself negatively towards the other, i.e., violates it. Where exactly it is that guilt and crime, along with doing and acting, will belong in universal ethical life will be given more determinate expression later, but this much is immediately clear. It is not *this singular individual* who acts and is guilty, for as *this* self, he is just the non-actual shade, or he is only as the universal self. Individuality is purely the *formal* moment of *doing* anything at all, and the content of the laws and mores is determined by his station in life. He is the substance as genus which through its determinateness becomes a species, but the species remains at the same time the universal of the genus. In the life of a people, self-consciousness descends from the universal only down to the point of particularity; it does not get as far as the point of singular individuality, which in its doings posits an excluding self, an actuality negative to itself. Rather, self-consciousness' action rests on a secure trust in the whole, where there is no admixture of anything alien, neither that of fear nor that of enmity.

468. In its deed, ethical self-consciousness now experiences the developed nature of *actual* acting, indeed, as much as it did when it submitted to both the divine and the human law. The law which is revealed to it is the essence bound up with its opposite. The essence is the unity of both, but the deed has only carried out the terms of one law in opposition to the other. However, interrelated in the essence with this other, the fulfillment of one law calls forth the other, and, with the deed having made it so, it calls forth the other as a violated and hostile essence now demanding revenge. As concerns the action, only one aspect of the decision itself lies open to the light of day. However, the decision is *in itself* the negative, which confronts an other to itself, an alien to itself, which is knowing. Hence, actuality keeps concealed within itself this other aspect which is alien to knowing and which does not show itself to consciousness as it is in and for itself – which neither shows the son that the man insulting him and whom he strikes dead is his father, nor shows him that the queen whom he takes as his wife is his mother. In this way, a power that shuns the daylight preys on ethical self-consciousness, a power which bursts forth only after the deed is done and when it has taken self-consciousness in its grip. This is so because the completed deed is the sublated opposition between the knowing self

and the actuality confronting it. The agent can neither deny the crime nor deny his guilt. – The deed consists in setting the unmoved into motion, which thereby brings forth what had been sealed off as mere possibility, and it links the unconscious to the conscious and the non-existent to being. In this truth, therefore, the deed comes to light – as that in which the conscious is combined with the unconscious and in which what is one's own is combined with what is alien. It comes to light as the estranged essence, whose other aspect consciousness also experiences as its own, as a power violated by it and thereby roused to hostility.

469. It can be that the right which lay in reserve is not present in its distinctive shape for the acting *consciousness* but is only present *in itself*, or in the inner guilt of the decision and the action. However, ethical consciousness is more complete and its guilt more pure if it *knows beforehand* the law and the power against which it takes an opposing stance, takes them to be violence and wrong, to be an ethical contingency, and then, like Antigone, knowingly commits the crime. The accomplished deed inverts its point of view. What the *accomplishment* itself expresses is that the *ethical* must be *actual*, for the *actuality* of the purpose is the purpose of acting. Acting directly expresses the *unity of actuality and substance*. It says that actuality is not accidental to essence, but rather that, in league with essence, there is nothing which is granted that is not a true right. On account of this actuality ethical consciousness must bestow recognition on its opposite, and on account of its own doing, ethical consciousness must acknowledge its guilt:

256 *Because we suffer, we recognize*³¹ that we have erred.³²

470. This recognition expresses the sublated conflict between ethical *purpose* and *actuality*, and it expresses the return to the ethical *disposition* which knows that nothing counts but the right. However, as a result the agent gives up his *character* and the *actuality* of his self and is brought to his downfall. His *being* is to belong to his ethical law as his substance, but in the recognition of the opposition, this law has ceased for him to be his substance, and instead of attaining his actuality, the agent has attained a non-actuality, a disposition.³³ – To be sure, the substance appears *in* individuality as *pathos*, and individuality appears as what brings the substance to life and hence stands above it. However, it is a pathos that is at the same time his character. Ethical individuality is immediately and in itself at one with its universal; it has existence only within it and is incapable of surviving the downfall that this ethical power suffers at the hands of its opposite.

³¹ *anerkennen*. ³² This is a quote from Sophocles' *Antigone*.

³³ *Gesinnung*. Alternatively this could be rendered "attitude," or "cast of mind."

471. However, in this situation ethical individuality has the certainty that the individuality whose pathos is this opposed power *suffers no more evil than it has inflicted*. The movement of the ethical powers against each other and the individualities which set these powers into life and action have therein reached their *true end* in that both sides experience the same demise. This is so because neither of the powers has any advantage over the other that would make it into a *more essential* moment of substance. The equal essentiality and indifferent stable existence which both have in their juxtaposition to each other is their self-less being; in the *deed* they are as independent beings³⁴ but as diverse, as what contradicts the unity of the self and which constitutes their utter lack of right and their necessary demise. According to its pathos, or its substance, *character* in part just as much belongs only to *one* power, and, according to the aspect of knowing, each is just as much estranged into the conscious and into the unconscious; and while each itself calls forth this opposition and is through its own deed its own work of not-knowing, each posits that it itself take on the guilt which devours it. The victory of one power and its character along with the conquest of the other would thus only be one part and would be the imperfect work which inexorably advances towards equilibrium. It is in the equal subjection of both sides that absolute right is first achieved, and ethical substance, as the negative power that devours both sides has emerged. That is, *fate*, omnipotent and just, has come on the scene.

472. If both powers are taken according to their determinate content and its individualization, then the picture that arises is that of their conflict as it has crystallized according to its formal aspect, as the antagonism which ethical life and self-consciousness bear towards both unconscious nature and a contingency made available through that nature – the latter, that is, nature, has a right against the former because the former is only *true* spirit, and it only is in an *immediate* unity with its substance – and, according to its content, the conflict is pictured as the schism between divine and human law. – Youth leaves the unconscious essence and the spirit of the family, and it becomes the individuality of the polity. However, that youth still belongs to the nature from which it has wrested itself away is demonstrated by youth's contingently emerging in the form of two brothers with equal rights to take possession of the polity. *For them*, who enter into the ethical essence, the inequality of earlier and later birth has, as a natural difference, no meaning. However, as the simple soul, or as the self of the spirit of the people, the government does not tolerate a dualism of individuality, and

257

³⁴ Selbstwesen.

by the accident of there being more than one, nature confronts the ethical necessity of this unity. For that reason, these two brothers are at odds with each other, and their equal right to the power of the state shatters both of them, each of whom is just as much in the wrong. Humanly considered, he who has committed the crime is the one who, because he was not *in possession* of his right, attacked the very polity in which the other stood at the head; in contrast, the one has right on his side who knew how to take the other only as a *singular individual* cut off from the polity and who, in finding him in this powerlessness, banished him from the polity. He struck at only the singular individual as such and not the polity; he did not strike at the essence of human right. Attacked and defended by empty singular individuality, the polity sustains itself, and it is through each other that the brothers come to their mutual demise, since individuality, which *in its being-for-itself* is linked to a danger to the whole, has expelled itself from the polity and dissolves itself. However, the polity will honor the one it found to be on its side; in contrast, the government, the re-established simplicity of the self of the polity, will punish the one who had already proclaimed on the walls of the city the devastation he would wreak, and this punishment will be that of denying him final honors. The one who assaulted the highest spirit of consciousness, the religious community,³⁵ must be stripped of the honor due to his fully perfected essence, or the honor due to the isolated spirit.

473. However much the universal so easily pushes off the pure tip of its pyramid and is *victorious* over the rebellious principle of singular individuality, or the family, still it has as a result committed itself to a *struggle* with divine law. This is a struggle between spirit conscious of itself and unconscious spirit, for unconscious spirit is the other essential power and is for that reason not destroyed but only offended by the conscious spirit. Yet confronting the authoritative law lying open to the light of day, unconscious spirit has a bloodless shade to help it put its law *actually* into effect. Hence, as the law of weakness and of darkness, it is initially subjugated to daylight's law and to its force, for its authority is only valid in the netherworld and not on the earth. However, the actual, which took its honor and power from the inner, has by doing so devoured its essence. The revealed spirit has the roots of its force in the netherworld; the people's self-reassuring *certainty* has the *truth* of its oath which binds them all into one only in the mute unconscious substance of all, in the waters of

³⁵ Gemeine. Although the most basic meaning is that of a community, Hegel uses it in another of its senses, namely, a religious community. He also uses *Gemeinde* more frequently to mean the same thing. In one place (paragraph 803), he uses the phrase, "*religiöse Gemeine*."

forgetfulness. The achievement of public spirit is thereby transformed into its opposite, and the public spirit experiences that its supreme right is supreme wrong and that its victory is instead its own downfall. For that reason, the dead individual whose right is infringed knows how to find instruments for his vengeance which are as actual and forceful as the power that injured him. These powers are other polities whose altars the dogs or birds defiled with the corpse, which was itself not elevated into unconscious universality by being appropriately returned to the elemental individual, the earth. Instead, it has remained above ground in the realm of actuality, and, as the force of divine law, it has now acquired a self-conscious, actual universality. These powers rise up in hostility and destroy the polity that has dishonored and disrupted its own force, the piety of the family.

474. In this representation, the movement of human and divine law has its necessity expressed in individuals in whom the universal appears as a *pathos*, and the movement's activity appears as an *individual* doing which bestows a semblance of contingency to the necessity of the movement. However, both individuality and doing constitute the principle of singular individuality as such, a principle which in its pure universality was called the inner divine law. As a moment of the polity made public, it does not only have the effectiveness of the netherworld, or an external effectiveness in its existence; it also just as much has a public, actual existence and movement in the actual people. Taken in this form, what was represented as the simple movement of the individualized pathos acquires a different look, and the crime together with the destruction of the polity (a destruction founded in that crime) acquire the real form of their existence. – Thus, in its universal existence, or the polity, human law *is* in its activity itself the manliness of the polity and *is* in its actual activity the government, and it *moves* itself and *sustains* itself by absorbing into itself the isolation of the Penates, or their self-sufficient individualization into different families over which women preside and which keep them dissolved within the continuity of its fluidity. However, the family is at the same time its elemental unit, and its universal energizing ground is singular consciousness. While the polity gives itself stable existence only by disrupting familial happiness and by dissolving self-consciousness in the universal, it creates an internal enemy for itself in what it suppresses, which is at the same time essential to it, or it creates an enemy in the feminine itself. By intrigue, the feminine – the polity's eternal irony – changes the government's universal purpose into a private purpose, transforms its universal activity into this determinate individual's work, and it inverts the state's universal property into the family's possession and ornament. In this way, the feminine turns to ridicule the

solemn wisdom of maturity, which, being dead to singular individuality – dead to pleasure and enjoyment as well as to actual activity – only thinks of and is concerned for the universal. The feminine turns this mature wisdom into an object of ridicule for immature, high-spirited youths and into an object of contempt for those youths' enthusiasm. As such, she elevates the force of youth into the status of what is validly established³⁶ – she elevates the force of the son, born to his mother as her master, and what counts is the force of the brother as one in whom the sister finds a man as an equal with herself, the man through whom the daughter, freed from her own non-self-sufficiency, achieves the enjoyment and the dignity of womanhood. – However, the polity can only sustain itself by suppressing this spirit of individuality, and because that spirit is an essential moment, the polity likewise creates it by its repressive stance towards it as a hostile principle. Nevertheless, since this principle, in separating itself from universal purposes, is only evil and is within itself null, it would be incapable of accomplishing anything if the polity itself were not to recognize the force of youth, or the manhood, which, although immature, still stands within individuality as the *force* of the whole. For the polity is a people, it is itself individuality, and it is so only essentially for *itself* in that *other individualities* are *for it* and in its *excluding* these from itself and knowing itself to be independent of them. The negative aspect of the polity, which directs itself *inward* and suppresses the isolation of the individual but which also directs itself *outward* and is *self-active*, has its weapons in individuality. War is the spirit and the form in which the essential moment of ethical substance, the absolute *freedom* of ethically *independent beings*³⁷ from all existence, is present in its actuality and in having proved itself. While, on the one hand, war makes the single *systems* of property and personal self-sufficiency as well as singular *personality* itself feel the force of the negative, in war this negative essence otherwise brings itself to the forefront as what sustains the whole. The brave youth, in whom the feminine has its pleasure, or the suppressed principle of corruption, comes now into full view and is what counts. Now what will render a decision on the existence of ethical essence and spiritual necessity is natural strength and what appears as the luck of the draw. Because the existence of ethical life thus rests on strength and chance, it has *already been decided* that it breathes its last. – Just as previously it was only the Penates in the spirit of the people which perished, now it is the *living* spirits of the people which perish through their individuality, and they collapse into one *universal* polity whose *simple universality*

260

³⁶ Geltenden.³⁷ Selbstwesens.

is devoid of spirit, is dead, and whose liveliness is the *singular* individual as singular. The ethical shape of spirit has disappeared, and another shape steps in to take its place.

475. This demise of ethical substance and its transition into another shape is determined, as a result, by this: That ethical consciousness is *immediately* directed towards the law, and this determination of immediacy means that nature itself enters into ethical life's action. Its actuality only reveals the contradiction and the germ of corruption which ethical spirit's beautiful unanimity and motionless equilibrium have in this motionlessness and beauty itself, for immediacy bears the contradictory meaning of being the unconscious restfulness of nature and the self-conscious restless restfulness of spirit. – On account of this naturalness, this ethical people per se is an individuality determined by nature and is thus a restricted individuality which finds its sublation in another individuality. However, this determinateness disappears, a determinateness which is posited as existing and which is a restriction, but which is also just as much the negative itself and the self of individuality. While this determinateness disappears, the life of spirit and this substance, which is conscious of itself in the self-consciousness of all, are both lost. In both of them, the substance emerges as a *formal universality* and no longer dwells in them as a living spirit. Instead, their simple unadulterated individuality has been shattered into a plurality of multiple points.

c. *The State of Legality*

476. The universal unity into which the living immediate unity of individuality and substance returns is the spiritless polity, a polity which has ceased to be the un-self-aware substance of individuals, and within which those individuals, according to their singular being-for-itself now each count as independent beings³⁸ and as substance. The universal is splintered into the atoms of absolutely multiple individuals; this spirit, having died, is an *equality* in which *all* count for as much as *each* and where each and all count as *persons*.³⁹ – What in the ethical world was called the hidden divine law has in fact emerged out of its innerness into actuality. In the former the *singular individual* was and counted as actual only as the universal *blood* of the *family*. As *this* singular individual, he was the *selfless departed*⁴⁰ *spirit*, but now he has emerged from out of his non-actuality. Because it is only ethical

261

³⁸ Selbstwesen.

³⁹ *Personen*. In this context, this means something more like “legal persons” or “normative persons.”

⁴⁰ *abgeschiedene*.